they knew the money so earned would now no longer be used for their benefit and would only fatten the jail staff's purses. As a result, garbage accumulated in the same way as in the past and the stench of decaying organic matter began pervading the jail campus.

Of course, claims continued to be made that the correctional reforms were proceeding as they had been and that nothing had been done to check them. However, those were but mere claims without any substantiation as there was no more any transparency. By a secret order, the Delhi Government prohibited access of the media to the prison. Organizations that had helped build up the education system in the jail and which had been so well accepted and liked by the inmates were told that the classes would be disturbed if they entered the prison. Even so, whenever they did manage to gain entry, they claimed that signals were passed to the staff within and the scenario soon became stage-managed. Jail factories slowed down almost to a stop because of lack of raw material and absence of supervision.

Saroj Vashisht was a very versatile and active social worker who had been interacting with the inmates of the prison for almost two years. She had organized cultural activity groups, poetry classes and teaching classes besides introducing a number of other measures. She maintained that as soon as the controversy about Kiran's activities in the jail started being reported in the newspapers, the inmates, by and large, had considered it to be a foregone conclusion that her transfer was imminent. A short time thereafter transfer orders were served to her. While the majority of the inmates almost felt bereaved, a small group of prison staff distributed sweets to all and sundry in the knowledge that their days of power and pelf in the confines of the prison walls had returned. Saroj stated that, by and large, the inmates were very disturbed about the fact that Kiran did not come to bid them farewell. 'It was a careful decision. I did not want to see men cry. Also this would have been the first time that I would have interacted with them and not been able to give any answers to their questions. Over and above, I was not going to give any opportunities to authorities to lay anything on me,' clarified Kiran. Her decision was a very judicious one if one were to go by what some of the prisoners had to say. They claimed that the situation in the jail was so volatile that the 1990 scenario could well have been repeated. They obviously were referring to the riots that had taken place then.

One of the prisoners who had spent almost four years in jail and was, more or less, the in-house poet claimed that the Chakkar Dharam Sabhas, i.e., the evening congregations of prisoners for spiritual discourses, and announcements that were so popular with the inmates just a short while ago, completely stopped and there was a marked segregation of Hindus, Muslims, Sikhs and Christians. Corruption, he added, was at the moment in its infancy and without fail it would soon bloom into its youth. He also noted that smoking was now back and an indicator of the easier access to tobacco was the sharp drop in prices of *beedis* and cigarettes.

A Kenyan, convicted of murder and who had completed his fourteen-year term, reminded Saroj of the times before Kiran was posted to Tihar. He had spent five years in a Kerala jail and been then shifted to Tihar because his life there had been at risk at the hands of a gang of smugglers. When he entered Tihar, he was given duties in the jail *langar* (kitchen) and soon told to pay the superintendent Rs 500 and the deputy superintendent Rs 300 per week. He did not know how to manage to do so and was therefore stripped naked, tied to a tree and beaten to near-death. After that he was explained that all he had to do was sell the rations coming to the *langar* to the prisoners and pay the officers from the money earned. To save his skin he had to resort to such a corrupt practice. He lamented the fact that he was seeing the same system returning and very soon the old days would be back again in Tihar. If anyone, he pointed out, could come to the foreign prisoners' wards he or she could see for himself or herself that a regular 'super bazaar' in drugs was functioning there.